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WHY LATIN AMERICA'S DEMOCRACIES ARE STUCK

Scott Mainwaring and Aníbal Pérez-Liñán

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From 1990 until the early 2010s, the big challenge facing democracy in most Latin American countries was its mediocre quality. The region had only one consolidated fully authoritarian regime, Cuba. With few exceptions, democratic breakdowns seemed to be a thing of the past. Democracy eroded sharply in Venezuela after 1999, but between 1985 and 2010, it deepened in Brazil, by far the region's most populous country. The low quality of democracy in most countries was a concern, but the region was enjoying its most democratic chapter.

In recent years, unfortunately, this situation has eroded, and Latin America is now contributing to the global decline of democracy. Across the region as a whole, democracy is in worse shape than it has been at any time since the late 1980s. Democratic stagnation with great deficits in democratic quality remains the most common situation, and where there has been marked change since 2002, it has been negative. Six countries have experienced democratic breakdowns or erosions, without a single clear case of democratic deepening to offset these declines. Venezuela and Nicaragua now have full-blown, highly repressive authoritarian regimes, joining the ranks of Cuba.

Democracy has eroded in Brazil and Mexico, the region's two largest countries, and El Salvador has devolved into a competitive authoritarian regime under President Nayib Bukele since his election in 2019. No country in the region has experienced meaningful democratic deepening since the Peruvian restoration of democracy in 2001, although Ecuador, in the aftermath of Lenín Moreno's 2017 presidential victory, did recover the mediocre level of democracy that

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it had enjoyed from 1980 until the 2007 election to the presidency of Rafael Correa.

Cases of erosion or breakdown punctuate an overall atmosphere of democratic stagnation. What do we mean by that term? The region's stagnant democracies (or semidemocracies) struggle with important and persistent democratic deficits that hold them back from becoming more solidly liberal democracies. In recent years, many scholars have written about executive takeovers and democratic backsliding, but few have discussed how the vast majority of countries in the "third wave" of democratization seem unable to make the move to higher-quality democracy. Instead, they stall out as low-grade democracies with major democratic deficits.[1]

Why is democratic deepening so hard and stagnation so common? We see three reasons. First, powerful groups such as organized criminal networks, unreformed police forces, and interests that belonged to the old authoritarian ruling coalition stand in the way. They have no wish to see citizens' rights protected, elections made more free and fair, executive power restrained, or armed actors such as paramilitaries or drug-cartel enforcers curbed or eliminated.

Second, poor governance results in most Latin American countries have fueled dissatisfaction with democracy, paving the way for authoritarian populists who rail against a failed establishment.

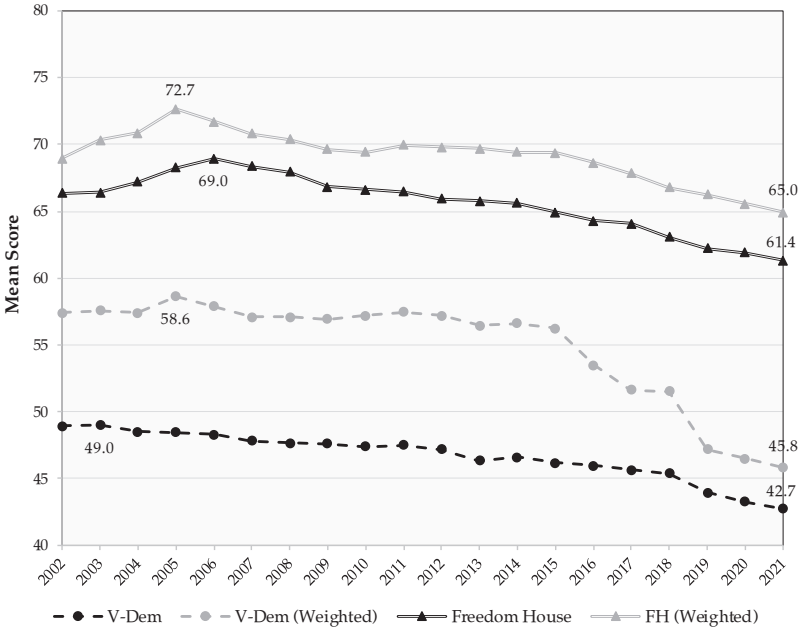
Third, what we call "hybrid states" violate citizens' rights, fail to provide citizen security and quality public services, and are partly captured by powerful state actors, politicians, and private interests that do not want to build more effective states based on the rule of law. Hybrid states combine some sectors of bureaucratic efficiency and innovation with others marked by corruption, patrimonialism, inefficiency, and authoritarianism. Together, coercive actors, poor results, and hybrid states have weakened citizens' commitment to democracy. This sets the stage for democratic stagnation and backsliding.

Latin America's Broad Patterns

We use the scores for liberal democracy published by the Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) project as well as Freedom House ratings to chart levels of democracy and processes of democratic deepening, stagnation, erosion, and breakdown. The 67 questions that V-Dem uses for its Liberal Democracy Index and the 25 questions that Freedom House uses for its 0 to 100 score tap the most important characteristics of liberal democracy.

Figure 1 shows V-Dem's average Liberal Democracy score for the twenty Latin American countries (rescaled in Figure 1 from 0 to 100) and Freedom House's average score on its 0 to 100 scale for 2002 (the first year it used that scale) to 2021. On both scales, a higher score shows

Figure 1—Trends in Latin American V-Dem Liberal-Democracy Index and Freedom House scores



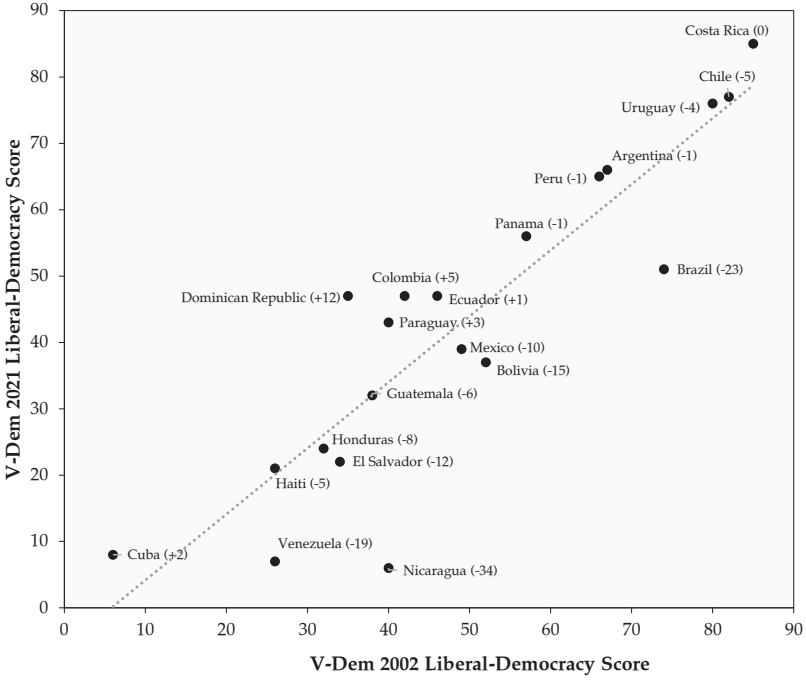
Note: Data labels show the highest and the 2021 data for each series.

Sources: Michael Coppedge et al., "V-Dem Country–Year Dataset v12," Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) Project; Freedom House, "Aggregate Category and Subcategory Scores, 2003–2022," *https://freedomhouse.org/sites/default/files/2022-02/Aggregate_Category_and_Subcategory_Scores_FIW_2003-2022.xlsx*.

a higher level of democracy. Figure 1 also shows the same information weighted by country population. Both leading measures of democracy show a worrisome if modest decline, starting in 2007 according to Freedom House and in 2004 according to V-Dem (in the unweighted data). Because the cases of erosion include the region's two largest countries, Brazil and Mexico—together, this pair is home to about 348 million of Latin America's 656 million people—the decline is steeper when the weighted scores are used. The decline has been gradual, but it is cumulatively meaningful, from 58.6 in 2005 to 45.8 in 2021 in the weighted V-Dem scale, with declines of 6 to 8 points from the high score to the 2021 score on the other three indicators.

These averages obscure great cross-country differences in both the level of democracy and the amount of change over the last two decades. Figure 2 shows V-Dem's 2021 Liberal Democracy scores (re-indexed from 0 to 100) for the Latin American countries on the vertical axis and the 2002 scores on the horizontal axis, with the difference between the two scores in parentheses.

FIGURE 2—V-DEM LIBERAL-DEMOCRACY SCORES, 2021 VS. 2002



Source: Michael Coppedge et al., "V-Dem Country–Year Dataset v12," Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) Project.

Figure 2 shows the prevalence of cases of net (i.e., simply comparing 2021 with 2002) democratic stagnation and erosion and the almost complete absence of cases of deepening. Six countries have eroded substantially (at least ten points on this scale). One (the Dominican Republic) improved by 12.5 points, and thirteen have shown little net change (less than ten points). Freedom House shows very similar patterns, with the same number (six) of cases of decline of at least ten points since 2002; only one case of deepening, Argentina; and the same number of cases (thirteen) showing little net change since 2002.

Latin America today hosts five categories of regimes (2021 V-Dem Liberal Democracy scores in parentheses):[2]

1) High-level liberal democracies: Costa Rica (85), Chile (77), and Uruguay (76).

2) Mid-level democracies: Argentina (66), Peru (65), Panama (56), and Brazil (51).

3) Low-level democracies and semidemocracies: Colombia, the Dominican Republic, and Ecuador (47 each); Paraguay (43);

Mexico (39); Bolivia (37); Guatemala (32); and Honduras (24).

4) Competitive authoritarian regimes: El Salvador (22) and Haiti (21). These are regimes "in which formal democratic institutions exist and are widely viewed as the primary means of gaining power, but in which incumbents' abuse of the state places them at a significant advantage vis-à-vis their opponents."[3]

5) Closed authoritarian regimes: Cuba (8), Venezuela (7), and Nicaragua (6).

The Roots of Democratic Stagnations

Democracy is a political regime that features: 1) free and fair elections for the legislature and executive; 2) nearly universal suffrage in today's world; 3) a broad set of political and civil rights such as freedom of expression, freedom of the press, and freedom to organize, among others; 4) mechanisms of accountability that can check executive power; and 5) civilian control over the military and other armed actors. Democratic deepening means enhancing one or more of these defining characteristics—for example, making the exercise of rights more even—such that the overall level of democracy improves.

One notable characteristic of Latin American political regimes in this century is the prevalence of many semidemocracies and low- to mid-level democracies coupled with the almost complete absence of cases of deepening. Twelve countries in the region today are semidemocracies or have a low to middling level of democracy, and they include the demographic giants Brazil (population 216 million) and Mexico (130 million). Democracy of middling or worse quality is Latin America's most common regime.

Most of these cases can be called instances of democratic stagnation. This involves three things: limited change in the level of democracy over a sustained period; a regime with substantial democratic deficits; and status as a semidemocracy (perhaps with intervals of competitive authoritarianism) or at best a mid-level democracy. Full-blown authoritarian regimes can liberalize and become less authoritarian, but it does not make conceptual sense to discuss *democratic* stagnation of closed authoritarian regimes. Likewise, a regime that is stable at a high level of democratic functioning (such as Sweden's) is not a case of stagnation—the word as used here means stasis at a significantly lower level of democratic functioning, with serious ongoing deficits.

Stagnations deserve more attention both because of how prevalent they are and because with the debatable exception of Venezuela, they have always been the prelude to executive takeovers of democracy in this region. Democratic stagnation is a common pattern in Latin America and in the third wave as a whole.[4] Six Latin American cases (Argen-

tina, Colombia, Guatemala, Panama, Paraguay, and Peru) meet stringent operational criteria for democratic stagnation.[5] Three more cases (the Dominican Republic, Ecuador, and Mexico) come close. Honduras and Bolivia experienced democratic breakdowns (in 2009 and 2019, respectively), but each has recently reestablished semidemocracy, returning to a level of democracy that is close to what had existed prior to the breakdown.

Democratic stagnation has occurred despite alternations in power involving very different partisan programs. In Mexico since the transition of 2000, the right, the center right, and the center left have each ruled in turn, but with no democratic deepening. Unlike some poor countries that made transitions to democracy during the third wave, Mexico is wealthy enough to have built a solid democracy: Its Gross Domestic Product (GDP) per capita is far higher than the level that early democratizing countries enjoyed at the time of democratization. Yet under no administration since 2000 has democratic deepening made headway.

Democratic stagnation is not inevitable; effective policies can help democratic forces while hindering those that limit democratization, and social movements can generate pressures to deepen democracy. But the obstacles are difficult to overcome, and the record shows relatively few clear cases of success at building robust democracies in Latin America and in the third wave more generally.

Thin Transitions, Potent Authoritarians

One factor behind stagnations is the power of actors that limit democracy. The wave of democratization that began in Latin America in 1978 and ended around 2001 touched every country in the region except Cuba, but it was shallow. Powerful actors—including subnational authoritarian actors, unreformed police forces, and authoritarian successor parties—kept it that way.

Mexico's national-level transition in 2000 came when the conservative National Action Party (PAN) won the presidency with candidate Vicente Fox. Mexico, it seemed, had at last broken with the past. But democratization had to be negotiated between opposition parties (including the PAN) and the long-ruling Institutional Revolutionary Party (PRI), which had governed at the national level since 1929. Until 2016, the PRI always ruled at least half of Mexico's 32 states, and in nine of them no other party had ever been in power from 1929 to 2016.[6] In most states where it governed, the PRI never changed its authoritarian ways. The old authoritarian PRI shaped Mexico's new democracy more than this democracy transformed the PRI. Most PRI-governed states remained islands of subnational authoritarianism despite democratic competition at the national level.[7] Worse, the influence of these subnational authoritarian regimes on national politics would prove deep, and that

influence persists to this day. The PRI returned to the presidency in 2012 and governed at the national level again until 2018. During this period, the party's collusion with organized crime reached new heights.

The current president, Andrés Manuel López Obrador (AMLO), comes from the PRI's authoritarian timber. Born in 1953, he began his political career as a PRI politician, splitting off (along with other center-left figures) in 1989 to start the Party of the Democratic Revolution (PRD), and then splitting again in 2011 to form his current party, known as Morena. Some PRD leaders left the PRI's authoritarianism behind, but AMLO was not among them. As PRD mayor of Mexico City in the early 2000s, he rejected judicial rulings he did not like, and his administration was rocked by a high-profile corruption scandal. He lost the 2006 presidential election narrowly and the 2012 election decisively, both times dubiously claiming that fraud had robbed him of victory. Mexicans' confidence in their electoral system predictably suffered as a result of AMLO's charges. As president, he has had an illiberal governing style, railing against democratic checks and balances and savaging his critics as self-interested obstacles to the public good.[8]

In most Mexican states, key power centers—the police, the judiciary, the state electoral authorities—have eluded reform. In Mexico as across most of Latin America, citizens' rights are de facto highly uneven. Police abuses of poor people's rights are widespread and sometimes dire.[9] The lack of police reform in a context of increasing drug-cartel violence has led to widening corruption and excessive uses of force by police agencies. In Brazil in 2020, police committed a staggering 6,416 homicides; almost four-fifths of the victims were black.[10] The comparable number of such killings in the United Kingdom (population 67 million) during the same year was five. In countries such as Mexico, where the military has assumed a major role in fighting organized crime, troops too have become major rights violators.[11]

There is nothing isolated about Mexico in these regards. Every Latin American country has seen forces from authoritarian times stay on as potent political actors. Since 2000, authoritarian successor parties have ruled in Bolivia, Chile, El Salvador, Guatemala, Mexico, Nicaragua, Panama, and Paraguay. As James Loxton argues, the electoral success of authoritarian successor parties makes them less likely to seek democracy's overthrow but also gives them leverage against democratizing reforms.[12]

Latin America's problem, moreover, is not merely one of holdovers. There are new actors given to blocking further democratization as well. Venezuela since 1998, Bolivia since 2005, and Ecuador since 2006 have seen new authoritarian forces emerge on the left, while Brazil since 2018 and El Salvador since 2019 have seen them coming from the right or (in the latter's case) an ideologically amorphous "center." In some countries, including Brazil, Evangelical churches have also been key parts of the coalition that favors democratic rollbacks.

Transnational criminal organizations are not new actors in Latin America, but their political power has expanded greatly in the last few decades, coinciding roughly with democratization. In parts of Brazil, Colombia, El Salvador, Guatemala, Honduras, and Mexico, they have devastated democracy at the local level, with consequences for national politics. Coercing candidates and voters, undermining the rule of law, and systematically violating citizens' rights and liberties, they sometimes also spark the formation of right-wing private militias to fight them. These too can readily turn into criminal gangs; in Colombia, conflict simmered for years among a toxic stew of drug syndicates, leftist guerrillas who sometimes behaved as common extortionists and kidnappers, and right-wing paramilitaries. The rightist militias have crippled democracy as much as the traditional criminal organizations. In countries including Brazil, Colombia, and Mexico, individuals who collude with criminal organizations and right-wing militias are no longer content to corrupt the police, prosecutors, and judges, but now run for office.

Such potent democracy-limiting actors can sentence countries to thin democratization and lower-grade democracy. The United States, the Organization of American States, and other international actors can discourage outright coups, but are less able to promote deepening democracy.

Thinking about democratization-averse actors can be useful for framing a strategy of democratic deepening—a task that has not been much on the radar of democratic governments or scholars. Can democrats nudge some of these difficult actors? Can others be neutralized or at least contained? Despite gestures here and there, democratic governments have not crafted conscious strategies for deepening democracy.

Governing Poorly

A second factor that has conspired against building deeper democracies and left some countries vulnerable to illiberal presidents has been disappointing governance. The average performance in most areas of central concern to citizens has been mediocre or worse.

The Table shows Latin American countries' average economic-growth rates since 1997, the Gini index of income inequality (a higher number means sharper inequality), the homicide rate, the Worldwide Governance Indicator for control of corruption (lower numbers are worse), and the World Rule of Law Index in the most recent year. While there is wide variance across the region on these key indicators of governance success, the median country fares poorly.

Most economies have grown at a sluggish rate over the last generation; the record of the three largest economies, Brazil, Mexico, and Argentina, is dismal. Latin America is perhaps the world's most violent and economically unequal region. In many countries, public security has been a huge problem. In 2022, El Salvador had the world's highest homicide

Table—Indicators of Governance in Latin America

	Annual per Capita GDP Growth (%)	Homicide Rate	GINI Index	Control of Corruption Index (2020)	Rule of Law Index (World Rank)
Argentina	0.4	5.3	42.3	-0.12	56th
Bolivia	1.8	7.0	43.6	-0.76	129th
Brazil	1.0	22.5	48.9	-0.34	77th
Chile	2.4	4.8	44.9	1.15	32th
Colombia	1.8	22.6	54.2	-0.18	86th
Costa Rica	2.6	11.2	49.3	0.78	31th
Cuba	2.9	5.0	–	-0.13	No Data
Dominican Rep.	3.5	8.9	39.6	-0.68	94th
Ecuador	0.8	7.8	47.3	-0.54	92th
El Salvador	1.4	37.2	38.8	-0.59	95th
Guatemala	1.5	17.5	48.3	-1.10	109th
Haiti	-0.1	6.7	41.1	-1.32	132th
Honduras	1.4	36.3	48.2	-0.86	126th
Mexico	0.5	28.4	45.4	-0.85	113th
Nicaragua	2.0	7.9	46.2	-1.25	131th
Panama	3.2	11.6	49.8	-0.51	71th
Paraguay	1.3	6.7	43.5	-0.87	96th
Peru	2.8	7.7	43.8	-0.49	87th
Uruguay	1.8	9.7	40.2	1.42	25th
Venezuela	–	49.9	44.8	-1.56	139th

Notes: GDP per capita growth measured in constant 2015 US dollars for 1997–2021. For Cuba, growth is calculated for 1997–2020 because the WDI did not show data for 2021.

Homicide rate reports the number of intentional homicides per 100,000 people in 2020 for most countries. For Bolivia, El Salvador, and Nicaragua, data are from 2019; for Haiti and Peru, from 2018; Venezuela, from 2017; Cuba, from 2016.

Gini index data are from 2020 for most countries; for El Salvador, Honduras, and Panama, data are from 2019; Guatemala and Nicaragua, from 2014; Haiti, from 2012; Venezuela, from 2006.

Sources: World Development Indicators for per capita GDP growth (indicator: NY.GDP.PCAP.KD), homicide rate (VC.IHR.PSRC.P5), and Gini index (SI.POV.GINI), *https://databank.worldbank.org/source/world-development-indicators*; Worldwide Governance Indicators for control of corruption, *https://info.worldbank.org/governance/wgi*.

rate according to the German data company *Statista.com,* with Honduras and Venezuela joining it in the top ten. Mexico, Brazil, Colombia, and Guatemala rounded out Latin America's representation in the top twenty. Going by the homicide rate, the nine most dangerous cities in the world and twelve of the most dangerous thirteen are in Latin America.

Only three Latin American countries rank among the world's top fifty in the World Rule of Law Index: Uruguay (25th), Costa Rica (31st), and Chile (32nd), and only one other, Argentina (56th), is in the top seven-

ty.[13] High-profile corruption scandals such as the Mensalão, Lava Jato (Car Wash), and Odebrecht affairs have plagued Latin America. The Worldwide Governance Indicator for control of corruption is based on a wide range of expert and citizen surveys. Scores are in standard deviations about or below the world mean in a given year. Seventeen of the twenty countries have below-average scores (Uruguay, Chile, and Costa Rica are the exceptions). Scandals have drained the legitimacy of establishment parties and created space for illiberal populists such as Brazil's Jair Bolsonaro, who claim that they will sweep away the entrenched rogues. The leftist Workers' Party (PT) governed Brazil from 2003 under President Lula da Silva. It became dogged by scandal after the *mensalão* scheme (an arrangement to bribe members of Congress for their support) broke in 2005. The Car Wash investigation began in 2014, the same year that the PT's poor economic management helped trigger a bruising recession. The party suffered large setbacks in the 2016 municipal elections, and the number of Brazilians identifying as PT supporters plunged.

The conservative establishment was also deeply tarnished by scandals, however, and after it impeached Lula's successor, President Dilma Rousseff, in 2016 and took the reins, it proved able neither to fix the economy nor to hide its own corruption. In the 2018 presidential election, voters turned against all establishment options and chose Bolsonaro, whose extreme views and tiny party made him a quasi-outsider despite his 27 years in Congress. He too, meanwhile, has come under suspicion of corrupt dealings: In July 2021, the Supreme Federal Tribunal (Brazil's highest court) authorized an investigation of him in relation to overspending on a covid vaccine produced in India and purchased by Brazil.[14]

Latin America's governance agenda was already freighted with difficulty when the pandemic hit in early 2020. The global commodities boom that had kicked off near the start of the century had begun to peter out around 2012. The boom decade had been good for most Latin American countries. Their economies grew, poverty fell, and inequalities long thought intractable began to shrink. The decade since 2012 has seen halts or reversals of these positive trends. Pandemic-related dislocations sent production and employment plunging, set levels of schooling back, and worsened poverty and inequality. In 2020, the region suffered its greatest economic contraction since modern record-keeping began 120 years ago.[15]

Latin American democracies and semidemocracies had long seemed surprisingly resilient in the face of mediocre governance records, but citizens eventually tired of poor performance. Voters' quest for something different enabled Hugo Chávez to win in Venezuela in 1998, and subsequent illiberal presidents to win in Bolivia, Ecuador, and Nicaragua in the 2000s. Likewise, the democratic erosion in El

Salvador since 2019 is hard to imagine without the mediocre or worse results that the country had long endured under both right- and left-wing governments.

Hybrid States, Stagnant Democracies

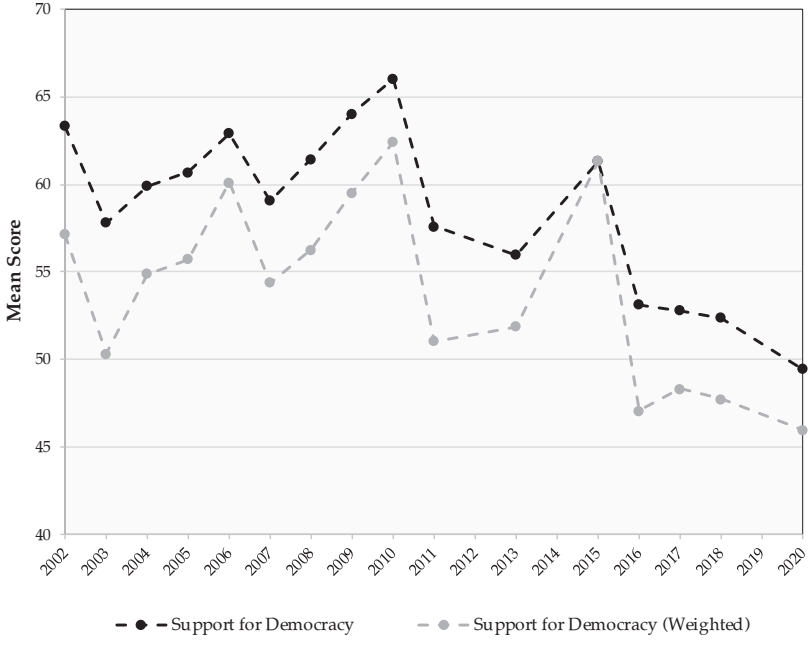
Hybrid states combine pockets of efficiency and democracy-respecting behavior with other, usually much larger pockets of inefficiency and authoritarian behavior. Modern states are asked to do a lot: internal policing and national defense, education and infrastructure, health care and housing, and pensions and unemployment insurance all fall within their writ. In democracies, the judicial system is charged with upholding citizen rights, and the judiciary and other state agencies are primarily responsible for what Guillermo O'Donnell called horizontal accountability.[16] Unfortunately, most Latin American states perform these tasks unevenly at best.

Three decades ago, O'Donnell noted that Latin American countries tended to be divided internally into what he called "blue zones" (almost always middle-class and wealthy areas where government ran fairly honestly and well) and "brown zones"—poor areas where inefficiency and authoritarian practices predominated.[17] Much has changed since O'Donnell wrote, but the hybrid character of most Latin American states remains. States have grown and social spending has risen. Between 1990 and 2020, taxes as a share of GDP increased by 40 percent across Latin America and the Caribbean, going from 15.6 to 21.9 percent.[18] State agencies in some countries have pioneered important innovations such as conditional cash transfers and participatory budgeting, but many bureaucracies remain quagmires of inefficiency and corruption, often captured by politicians, officials, and powerful private interests.[19] In some countries, the police, judges and prosecutors, and state agents collude with criminal groups.

Across most of Latin America, poor state quality and capacity work against democratic deepening. If not outright corrupt, police and prosecutors may be weak and incompetent. Chronic offenses go unpunished, driving citizens to fury, or perhaps just political apathy and cynicism. Higher social spending has not, by and large, produced commensurate improvements in human well-being. Under democracy, far more Latin Americans go to school, but the quality of public education remains poor. Even countries with good public-health systems, such as Brazil, were not up to the task of managing the covid pandemic. All this has helped to discredit establishment parties and open the way for populist outsiders.

In Chile, Costa Rica, and Uruguay, the state tends to function well. As the Table shows, these countries have low homicide rates and good scores on the Worldwide Governance Indicator for Control of Corrup-

Figure 3—Citizen Support for Democracy in 18 Latin American Countries, 2002–20



Source: Latinobarómetro data bank, *https://www.latinobarometro.org/latContents.jsp*.

Note: Percentage of respondents who agreed with the statement "Democracy is preferable to any other kind of government." Latinobarómetro data on support for democracy do not include Cuba and Haiti, and there are no data for the Dominican Republic in 2002 and 2003.

tion and the World Rule of Law Index. Yet these three are the region's exceptions, separated from the rest of Latin America by a considerable gap in state performance and quality.

The Illiberal Wave

The combination of hybrid states, poor governance records, and criminal networks and entrenched actors opposed to democratic deepening has kept most of Latin America democratically stagnant. With this stagnation has come declining citizen commitment to democracy, as Figure 3 shows. The trend bears a resemblance to the democracy trends in Figure 1.

Democratic breakdowns via executive takeovers and deep erosions of democracy require one more ingredient: illiberal presidents who purposefully undermine democracy. Absent illiberal presidents, democracy in the region has not deepened, but nor has it sharply eroded.[20]

Most Latin American semidemocracies and democracies avoided breakdowns and erosions in the 1980s and 1990s, the first two decades of the third wave. Over time, however, Latin American voters tired of

political systems that failed to give them what they needed and wanted. In large numbers, they turned against establishment parties and in many countries voted for populists who promised to govern for the people and against the establishment. Hugo Chávez's election in Venezuela in 1998 marked the beginning of the left turn in Latin American politics. The leftist tide included some presidents who fought to deepen democracy during the century's first decade (Ricardo Lagos in Chile, for example, and in important respects Lula in Brazil), but it also included illiberal populists who led a new wave of democratic erosions and breakdowns, including Chávez in Venezuela, Correa in Ecuador, Evo Morales in Bolivia, and Ortega in Nicaragua. The cresting of this tide roughly coincided with the end of the commodities boom, but hostility to the establishment did not vanish. On the contrary, as economic growth and social progress slowed, the populist temptation sharpened. Most party systems in the region continue to be marked by high electoral volatility, high distrust, and low partisan attachment, ideal conditions for populist challengers seeking to overtake established parties.

The election of the authoritarian right-winger Jair Bolsonaro in Brazil, and of the center-left populist AMLO in Mexico, both in 2018, reinvigorated the populist wave. They had been preceded by the right-wing populist Jimmy Morales in Guatemala (2016–20) and followed by Nayib Bukele in El Salvador in 2019, who rapidly captured the courts after his party's landslide victory in the congressional elections of 2021, and by leftist Pedro Castillo in Peru in 2021. Suspicion of the establishment and widespread citizen frustration with poor governance have fueled explosive social protests in Bolivia, Brazil, Chile, Colombia, Nicaragua, Peru, Venezuela, and elsewhere over the last few years. There are now left-of-center presidents in Argentina, Bolivia, Brazil, Chile, Colombia, Honduras, Mexico, and Peru. Thus another left turn is well under way, but amid governing conditions far more difficult than during the commodity boom.

The international political environment today is less favorable for democracy than in the first decades of the third wave, given China's greater involvement in the region and a more equivocal U.S. posture. The parlous state of most Latin American economies today adds to the difficulties of building deeper democracies, though it also adds to the difficulty of consolidating authoritarian regimes.

The Toughest Years Since 1990

Although Latin America is still living in a more democratic time than it enjoyed before the late 1970s, these are the toughest times for democracy the region has seen since about 1990. Stagnation with deep democratic deficits is widespread, and since the current century began, nearly all cases of marked change in the level of democracy have involved

erosion or breakdown. Democracy has eroded in Bolivia, Brazil, and Mexico. El Salvador has devolved into competitive authoritarianism, while Nicaragua and Venezuela have joined Cuba in the full-blown, highly repressive authoritarian camp.

Three factors have contributed to the widespread pattern of democratic stagnations and have increased the incidence of democratic erosion and collapse. First, older authoritarian actors block democratic deepening while newer authoritarian actors, especially organized crime and right-wing militias, often radically undermine democratic rights. Second, in many countries, mediocre or worse government performance leaves angry citizens surveying their discontents in the areas of economic growth, inequality, public security, corruption control, and other salient issues, and paves the way for illiberal presidents to attack democracy. Third, the inefficient, authoritarian, and often corrupt agencies within hybrid states have directly limited democratic deepening and fueled citizens' discontent.

Democratic stagnation facilitates the rise of illiberal presidents who rail against the system. These illiberal presidents sometimes succeed in dismantling democracy, and they sometimes fail. When they fail, the political regime has reverted to the familiar status of semidemocracy, or perhaps a mid-performing democracy at best. How to break out of this rut and build democracies that function better and show more respect for citizens' rights is one of the great challenges facing Latin America today.

NOTES

1. An exception is Sebastián L. Mazzuca and Gerardo L. Munck, *A Middle-Quality Institutional Trap: Democracy and State Capacity in Latin America* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2020).

2. A cut point of 0.70 on V-Dem's Liberal Democracy Index is a reasonable dividing line between high- and medium-quality democracies. A cut point of 0.50 on this index is a reasonable dividing line between medium-quality democracies and low-level democracies or semidemocracies. Following V-Dem scholars, a score of at least 0.50 on the Electoral Democracy Index can demarcate the boundary between semidemocracies and competitive authoritarian regimes.

3. Steven Levitsky and Lucan A. Way, *Competitive Authoritarianism: Hybrid Regimes After the Cold War* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2010).

4. Scott Mainwaring and Fernando Bizzarro, "Outcomes After Transitions in Third Wave Democracies," in Leonardo A. Morlino, Dirk Berg-Schlosser, and Bertrand Badie, eds., *The SAGE Handbook of Political Science* (London: Sage, 2020): 1540–57.

5. The criteria are that 1) the 2021 V-Dem Liberal Democracy score is within ten points of the 2002 score; 2) the gap between the highest score and the lowest during the 2002–21 period is less than fifteen points; 3) the regime did not break down or turn into a clearly authoritarian regime; and 4) the 2021 V-Dem score is below 70.

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cessor Party and Its Consequences for Democracy," in James Loxton and Scott Mainwaring, eds., *Life After Dictatorship: Authoritarian Successor Parties Worldwide* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2018), 264–65.

7. Edward L. Gibson, *Boundary Control: Subnational Authoritarianism in Federal Democracies* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2012).

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9. Daniel Brinks, *The Judicial Response to Police Killings in Latin America: Inequality and the Rule of Law* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2008); Yanilda María González, *Authoritarian Police in Democracy* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2020).

10. "Murders, Killings by Police Rose in Brazil Last Year, Report Shows," Reuters, 15 July 2021, *www.reuters.com/world/americas/murders-killings-by-police-rose-brazil-last-year-report-shows-2021-07-15*.

11. Gustavo A. Flores-Macías and Jessica Zarkin, "The Militarization of Law Enforcement: Evidence from Latin America," *Perspectives on Politics* 19 (June 2021): 519–38; Natalia Viana, *Dano Colateral: A Intervenção dos Militares na Segurança Pública* (Rio de Janeiro: Editora Objetiva, 2021).

12. James Loxton, "Introduction: Authoritarian Successor Parties Worldwide," in Loxton and Mainwaring, eds., *Life After Dictatorship,* 1–49.

13. World Justice Project, Rule of Law Index 2021, *https://worldjusticeproject.org/sites/default/files/documents/WJP-INDEX-21.pdf*.

14. Mariana Muniz, "STF autoriza investigação de Bolsonaro por prevaricação no caso Covaxin," *O Globo* (Rio de Janeiro), 2 July 2021.

15. See Comisión Económica para América Latina y el Caribe (CEPAL), *Los impactos sociodemográficos de la pandemia de Covid-19 en América Latina y el Caribe* (LC/CRPD.4/3) (Santiago, Chile, 2022), especially p. 18 for data on the sharp economic contraction.

16. Guillermo O'Donnell, "Delegative Democracy," *Journal of Democracy* 5 (January 1994): 55–69.

17. Guillermo O'Donnell, "On the State, Democratization, and Some Conceptual Problems: A Latin American View with Glances at Some Postcommunist Countries," *World Development* 21 (August 1993): 1355–69.

18. *Revenue Statistics in Latin America and the Caribbean* (Paris: OECD Press, 2022), 22.

19. Matthew M. Taylor, *Decadent Developmentalism: The Political Economy of Democratic Brazil* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2020); Barbara Geddes, *Politician's Dilemma: Building State Capacity in Latin America* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1994). For similarities in Africa, see Erin Metz McDonnell, *Patchwork Leviathan: Pockets of Bureaucratic Effectiveness in Developing States* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2020).

20. Brazilian democracy initiated a trend toward erosion in the absence of an illiberal chief executive, mainly as a result of Congress's questionable impeachment of President Dilma Rousseff (the charges included technical violations of a budgeting law) in 2016. What initially appeared to be a short-term trend extended itself with the election of President Jair Bolsonaro in 2018.